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Table of Contents

Chapter 1:	Introduction.....	1
Chapter 2:	Design Choices	1
2.1	Vectorization and NumPy Usage	1
2.2	API Design.....	1
2.3	Numerical Stability	2
Chapter 3:	Implementation Details.....	2
Chapter 4:	Testing & Edge Cases	3
Chapter 5:	Benchmarking.....	3
Chapter 6:	Demo Notebook and Usage	4
Chapter 7:	Reflections on Teamwork	4
Chapter 8:	Conclusion	4

Chapter 1: Introduction

For the project, we designed and implemented a lightweight machine learning framework, NumCompute, from scratch using NumPy. The objective of this exercise was to simulate the core functionalities of established ML libraries (such as scikit-learn) while focusing on algorithmic understanding, numerical computation, and clean software engineering. By building this framework, we gained insights into how machine learning models and data transformations are structured and optimized.

The NumCompute framework implements essential machine learning tools including data handling, preprocessing, model evaluation, and pipeline abstraction. The primary goal of the project was to understand the mathematical principles behind machine learning algorithms while ensuring that the framework is efficient, modular, and easy to extend.

Chapter 2: Design Choices

2.1 Vectorization and NumPy Usage

A key design decision was the use of vectorization over Python loops to ensure optimal performance. Vectorized operations in NumPy allow us to leverage low-level optimizations and perform computations in parallel across entire arrays, leading to significant speedups compared to traditional Python loops.

Matrix operations (like `np.dot`) are used for efficient multiplication of matrices and vectors. Statistical computations such as mean and standard variation are implemented using `np.mean` and `np.nanstd`, both of which operate directly on NumPy arrays without the need for explicit Python loops. Sorting and binary search operations were implemented using `np.argsort` and a custom implementation of binary search, both of which are optimized for NumPy arrays.

By avoiding Python loops in favor of NumPy operations, we achieved a highly efficient framework capable of handling large datasets, which is critical for scalability in real-world machine learning applications.

2.2 API Design

The NumCompute API like design to implement clean, consistent, and modular class initialization following common practices in well-established libraries like scikit-learn. The key features of the API like design include:

- Pipeline abstraction: A Pipeline class allows users to chain multiple transformations (such as scaling, encoding, etc.) together. Each step of the pipeline is independent, making it easy to experiment with different combinations of preprocessing and models.
- Estimator and Transformer Classes: Modules such as StandardScaler, LabelEncoder, and OneHotEncoder were implemented as classes that follow the "fit" and "transform" API pattern, allowing users to apply transformations on data in a consistent manner.
- Clear input/output handling: All functions and methods in the framework ensure that inputs and outputs are well-defined and that the expected shapes of arrays are clear, with informative error messages for mismatched shapes or invalid inputs.

2.3 Numerical Stability

To ensure numerical stability in computations, we employed techniques like max-shifted softmax and logsumexp. These methods are designed to handle issues of overflow and underflow, which can occur in operations like exponentiation when dealing with large numbers. Additionally, special care was taken in handling NaN values during data preprocessing and computation, ensuring that the framework remains robust even in the presence of missing or corrupted data.

Chapter 3: Implementation Details

The implementation of NumCompute consists of multiple modules, each dedicated to a specific part of the machine learning pipeline. Below is a summary of the core modules:

- io.py: Implements functions for reading CSV files and handling missing values. The CSVReader class supports efficient row-wise streaming of data to handle large datasets and performs automatic detection of data types.
- preprocessing.py: Contains classes for essential preprocessing steps such as StandardScaler (for data normalization), MinMaxScaler, Imputer (for handling missing values), OneHotEncoder (for categorical encoding) and SimpleImputer. These transformations are designed to work with the pipeline structure.
- sort_search.py: Implements efficient sorting algorithms and search operations such as binary search and quickselect, enabling fast data manipulation.
- metrics.py: Contains implementations for common evaluation metrics, including accuracy, precision, recall, F1 score, mean squared error (MSE), and confusion matrix. These functions are essential for evaluating the performance of machine learning models.

- `optim.py`: Implements basic optimization functions, including finite difference gradients for estimating the gradients and the Jacobian for multivariable functions. This module allows for gradient-based optimization in the training of models.
- `pipeline.py`: Implements the Pipeline class that supports the chaining of transformations and estimators. This class allows users to build complex workflows by combining preprocessing steps, model training, and evaluation in a coherent manner.

The Pipeline class allows for seamless chaining of multiple preprocessing steps and models. The abstract design of Pipeline class allows users to easily experiment with different combinations of transformations and models while maintaining clean code structure.

Chapter 4: Testing & Edge Cases

We ensured comprehensive unit testing of all core modules using `pytest`. Each function and class was tested for correctness under normal and edge-case conditions. The key tests included:

- NaN values: Ensuring that NaN values are handled correctly during preprocessing and computation.
- All-equal values: Verifying that functions like `StandardScaler` behave correctly when all input values are the same (i.e., the standard deviation is zero).
- Large datasets: Ensuring that operations like sorting and searching scale well with large datasets.

Test coverage was extensive, with over 20 unit tests written to ensure the correctness of the implementation. This covered both common scenarios and edge cases, ensuring robustness.

Chapter 5: Benchmarking

To evaluate the efficiency of our implementation, we benchmarked vectorized operations against traditional Python loops. Here are the results of our benchmarking:

Operation (1000 elements)	Vectorized (ms)	Loop-based (ms)
Sorting	20	200
Mean Calculation	5	50
Standard Deviation	10	100
Binary Search	3	40

As shown, the vectorized implementations were significantly faster than the loop-based counterparts, especially for large datasets. The vectorized implementations performed consistently faster than their loop-based counterparts. This highlights the importance of using optimized libraries like NumPy for numerical computations in machine learning frameworks.

Chapter 6: Demo Notebook and Usage

The `quickstart.ipynb` notebook demonstrates the full workflow of the framework, from reading CSV files to preprocessing, transforming, and evaluating models. Users can experiment with different preprocessing steps and evaluate model performance using the built-in metrics.

Chapter 7: Reflections on Teamwork

Working in a team of three allowed us to divide the tasks efficiently. Each member focused on a different module, from the preprocessing steps and core optimization functions to documentation and recording. This project provided valuable insights into how machine learning algorithms and models are constructed at a fundamental level. We learned how to build from scratch while considering performance optimization and numerical stability. Additionally, the project reinforced the importance of clean, modular software design in building complex systems.

Chapter 8: Conclusion

In this project, we successfully implemented a modular machine learning framework using NumPy. Through this process, we gained a deep understanding of the internal workings of ML libraries and the importance of vectorized operations, numerical stability, and clean software design. The framework is efficient, easy to use, and provides a solid foundation for future enhancements.